

The Windows Media Player 9 series has revised its codec technology, thereby allowing for smaller file sizes with better sound quality. Its Radio Tuner lists numerous radio stations. You can listen to some—ClassicalMusicAmerica.com, for example—from within the software. Others, such as Ultimate-80s (www.ultimate80s.com), requires you to log on to their Web site.

If your Internet connection is slow, and you experience frequent pauses due to buffering, here's what you can do. In Windows Media Player, go to **Tools > Options**, switch to the Performance tab, and set the buffer time to 60 in the Network Buffering area.

Use Winamp 5 to watch Internet TV. First, to filter offensive content, press [Control]+[P] to bring up the Preferences dialog box. Click on Media Library and switch to the 'Internet Radio/TV' tab.

Here, tick the appropriate rating of the channel you want to see, and click OK. Now, go to **File > Internet TV**, and then double-click the desired channel.

If radio is on your mind, click **File > Internet Radio** instead. Here, you'll find practically every listening option—news, Hindi music, western music, comedy, etc.

As you hit a Web site in your search for channels, you come across another Web address that offers some more, and thus your range of choices expands. You get a lot more channels to peruse than what media player software can offer. However, do remember that most of these are customised for Internet Explorer. Browsers such as Opera may not display them properly.

Do Re Mi...

LAUNCHcast, a unique music service by Yahoo!s Launch (<http://launch.yahoo.com>), lets you customise your radio stations. It claims to be the only such free service, with unlimited artists, albums and song ratings in tow. However, you can only listen to 400 songs per month. Beyond that, restrictions such as a ban on further customisation apply. To use LAUNCHcast, you need to have Internet Explorer 5.5 or higher, and at least Macromedia Flash 6.0.

Iceberg Radio (www.icebergradio.com) is another online station worth tuning into. It has around 250 channels, distributed across categories that include Comedy, Oldies, Opera, etc. Do remember that you need to register—for free—before you sing along. BBC (www.bbc.co.uk/radio/) also has several music channels guaranteed to keep you hooked.

Sa Re Ga...

With sections named Forthcoming, Instrumental, Classical, Meditations, Pop, Oldies,

Ghazals,

Remixes etc., Smashits

(www.smashits.com) has one of the largest collections of Indian sur. Regional music finds its place here in sections devoted to Bhangra, Bengali, Carnatic, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Tamil, Telugu and north Indian classical music.

Its radio stations are sorted by singer, music director, actor or actress, year of release, etc. That isn't all—there are movie trailers, song clips, screensavers, wallpapers, jokes, astrology, and even e-greetings. Register for free, and create WebCDs—online albums comprising numbers of your choice!

Although Raaga (www.raaga.com) has a smaller collection than Smashits, the audio quality is slightly better. It has three sections—Hindi, Tamil and Telugu. Here too, albums are grouped by actors, actresses, singers, music directors, etc. You'll also find lyrics of selected songs.

In the mood for some Bhangra? PunjabiSongs.com (www.punjabisongs.com) is just what you need. Apna Radio (www.apnaradio.com), too, has some decent Punjabi fare. Groove to the beat of Indian folk music at Beat of India (www.beatofindia.com). Music India OnLine (www.musicindiaonline.com) and the music section of AllIndianSite.com (www.allindiansite.com) are also worth a mention for their collection of Bharatiya Sangeet.

Views on news

Think news, and you probably think BBC; so head to www.bbc.co.uk/radio. It has news channels in 42 languages, including BBC Hindi. CNET Radio (

Find a big collection of Indian music at www.smashits.com